

Comprehensive Disaster Response Guide

FEMA Applications, Wildfire Risk Reduction, and Damage Level Assessments

1. How to Apply for FEMA Aid After a Disaster

Following a declared disaster, applying for FEMA assistance is the critical first step to recovery. The process is designed to evaluate your housing needs, uninsured losses, and basic necessary expenses.

Primary Application Methods

- **By Phone:** Call the toll-free application number at **1-800-621-FEMA (3362)**. (TTY: 1-800-462-7585)
- **Online:** Register at **www.fema.gov** or via the disasterassistance.gov portal.

Note: These are the ONLY official ways to apply for initial assistance.

The Application and Assessment Process

- **Initial Information:** You will be asked to provide general details about your household income, existing insurance coverage, damage to your primary residence, and immediate housing needs.
- **Application Number:** Upon registering, you will receive an application number. Keep this secure, as it is required to track your file in the FEMA system.
- **FEMA Inspector Visit:** A few days after applying, a FEMA inspector will contact you to arrange a visit to your damaged home or apartment to verify disaster-related damages for the Individuals and Households Program.
- **Verification:** You must present identification and sign a document verifying your U.S. citizenship, non-citizen national status, or qualified alien status at the time of the disaster.

The SBA Loan Integration

After applying to FEMA, you may receive a loan packet from the U.S. Small Business Administration (SBA). **It is crucial to fill out and return this packet.** If you do not return the SBA application, you

may be disqualified from receiving other types of FEMA assistance. SBA offers low-interest loans up to \$200,000 for homeowners' real estate repairs, and up to \$40,000 for renters/homeowners to replace personal property.

2. Wildfire Mitigation and Response

Wildfires present unique, fast-moving threats to property. Addressing a wildfire incident involves both immediate post-fire recovery actions and proactive risk reduction steps.

What to Do After a Wildfire

- **Notify Insurance and FEMA:** Contact your insurance carrier immediately to report the loss. Register for FEMA benefits concurrently to see if you qualify for federal relief.
- **Document the Damage:** Once the fire department declares it safe to return, extensively document the damage with photos and videos before beginning any clean-up.
- **Prevent Further Damage:** Make immediate, temporary repairs (e.g., covering broken windows or damaged roofs) to protect insured property from further exposure to the elements. Keep itemized invoices.
- **Keep Records:** Save all receipts related to restoration, hotel stays, or temporary relocation, and begin replacing vital documents lost in the fire.

Steps to Reduce Wildfire Risk (Mitigation)

To reduce wildfire risk around your area and protect your property from future incidents, implement the following mitigation steps:

- **Create Defensible Space:** Clear dead brush, dry grass, leaves, and pine needles from within at least 30 to 100 feet of your home.
- **Hardscape and Clean:** Keep gutters and roofs completely clear of debris, which can easily catch fire from flying embers.
- **Use Fire-Resistant Materials:** When rebuilding or repairing, use non-combustible roofing, fire-resistant siding, and dual-paned windows.
- **Trim Vegetation:** Prune tree branches so they do not overhang the roof or touch the sides of the structure. Keep the lowest branches at least 6 to 10 feet off the ground.
- **Store Combustibles Safely:** Keep firewood, propane tanks, and other flammable materials at least 30 feet away from the main structure.

3. How FEMA Damage Levels Are Determined

When a FEMA inspector visits your property, they categorize the severity of the damage into one of four standard levels. These levels determine eligibility and the amount of assistance provided.

DESTROYED

The home or business is a total loss or damaged to such an extent that repairs are not economically feasible.

- The structure is permanently uninhabitable.
- Complete failure of major structural components (foundation, load-bearing walls, roof).
- **Flood Example:** Over 5 feet of water on the first floor, or a basement full with over 2 feet of water on the first floor.
- **Wind Example:** House pushed off the foundation, or two or more walls destroyed with substantial roof damage.

MAJOR DAMAGE

The structure has sustained significant structural damage, is currently uninhabitable, and requires extensive repairs, but is not a total loss.

- Substantial failure of structural elements (walls, floors, foundation).
- More than 50% damage to the overall structure.
- **Flood Example:** 2 to 5 feet of water on the first floor (without a basement), or over 8 feet in a basement causing collapsed walls.
- **Wind Example:** Shifted on foundation/piers, or substantial structural damage to the roof and walls.

MINOR DAMAGE

The home or business is damaged and uninhabitable, but can be made habitable in a short period of time with relatively minor repairs.

- Has less than 50% damage to the structure.
- **Flood Example:** 1 to 2 feet of water on the first floor, or 1 to 8 feet in a basement affecting the furnace/water heater.
- **Wind Example:** One wall damaged, a section of the roof missing, or blown-in windows/doors.

AFFECTED

The dwelling or building sustained minimal damage to the structure or contents, and the home or business remains habitable without immediate repairs.

- Minimal cosmetic damage that does not impact the safety or function of the home.
- **Flood Example:** Less than 12 inches of water on the first floor or in the basement, with no structural damage.
- **Wind Example:** A few broken windows, some missing shingles, or minor dents to siding.